Profile of a Criminal: Ajmal Kasab and the 26/11 Mumbai Attacks

Introduction

Terrorism has long been defined as the use of violence and intimidation to achieve political, religious, or ideological objectives. Hoffman, 2006 says "anyone who attempts to further his views by a system of coercive intimidation" (Hoffman 2006). This definition remains relevant in modern discussions of radicalization and extremist violence. One of the most devastating terrorist incidents in recent history was the 26/11 Mumbai attacks, which took place in November 2008. The attack was carried out by 10 armed militants from Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), a Pakistan-based terrorist organization, and resulted in 175 deaths, including nine attackers, and over 300 injuries (Raman, 2009).

Among these attackers, Ajmal Kasab stood out as the only one captured alive. His testimony and trial provided crucial insights into the radicalization of youth into terrorist organizations (BBC News, 2012). Kasab's journey from a poor rural background to participating in one of the deadliest terrorist attacks in India exemplifies how social theories of offending, particularly social learning theory, strain theory, and social control theory, explain the process of radicalization. This paper examines Kasab's background, the influence of extremist ideology, and how social theory explains his involvement in terrorism.

Background of Ajmal Kasab

Ajmal Kasab was born in Faridkot, Pakistan, in 1987. He came from an impoverished background; his father sold food for a living, and he received little formal education. Dissatisfied with his family's economic struggles, he left home at a young age, moving to Lahore, where he engaged in petty crimes and low-wage labor. His life took a drastic turn when he encountered Lashkar-e-Taiba recruiters in Rawalpindi's Raja Bazaar, where he initially sought firearms for criminal activities. (BBC News, 2012)

LeT provided Kasab with ideological indoctrination and military training, starting with a 21-day Daura-e-Sufa (preliminary training), followed by an advanced 8-week training program (Raman, 2009). He was trained in assault rifles, explosives, survival tactics, and navigation. The organization convinced him that he was engaging in jihad to avenge perceived injustices against Muslims in Kashmir and around the world (Hindustan Times, 2018). He was ultimately selected as one of the ten operatives deployed for the 26/11 attack.

Social Theory of Offending and Terrorism

Several criminological theories explain the development of criminal behavior, and terrorism is no exception. Social learning theory, strain theory, and social control theory provide a framework for understanding radicalization.

Social Learning Theory, proposed by Bandura (1977), suggests that individuals learn behaviors through observation, imitation, and reinforcement. Terrorist organizations often recruit members by exposing them to violent ideologies, glorifying martyrdom, and fostering a sense of belonging through extremist networks (Akers, 1998).

Strain Theory, introduced by Merton (1938) and expanded by Agnew (1992), posits that when individuals experience social or economic strain, they may turn to crime as an alternative means to achieve success. In Kasab's case, his poverty and lack of opportunities made him susceptible to terrorist recruitment.

Social Control Theory, developed by Hirschi (1969), argues that individuals refrain from crime due to strong social bonds with family, education, and institutions. Kasab's weak ties to family and society made him more vulnerable to extremist influence.

These theories collectively explain how individuals like Kasab can be radicalized and coerced into acts of terrorism.

Applying Social Theory to Kasab's Radicalization

Social Learning Theory: The Role of Indoctrination and Propaganda

Kasab's transformation into a terrorist was facilitated by his exposure to radical teachings and training camps. Hafiz Saeed, the founder of LeT, personally indoctrinated recruits by delivering speeches on jihad and portraying non-Muslims as enemies (Raman, 2009). Kasab's training included exposure to media propaganda, where he and other recruits were shown videos and images of violence against Muslims, creating a psychological justification for their actions. Military-style conditioning involved combat drills and religious rhetoric to reinforce extremist beliefs, while group reinforcement ensured that Kasab was constantly

surrounded by individuals who shared and encouraged his radical ideology (BBC News, 2012).

This aligns with Bandura's (1977) social learning theory, which states that people adopt behaviors by observing influential figures. Kasab's environment normalized violence, reinforcing terrorist actions as honorable.

Strain Theory: Economic Hardship and Political Influence

Kasab's early life was marked by poverty and lack of opportunity. According to Merton's strain theory (1938), when individuals experience societal pressure but lack legal means to achieve success, they may resort to deviant behavior. Kasab's financial struggles and inability to support himself pushed him toward crime, and eventually, he saw terrorism as an escape.

LeT exploited this economic vulnerability by promising financial rewards to Kasab's family (Hindustan Times, 2018). Recruiters convinced him that he was fighting a war for justice, framing terrorism as a legitimate path to dignity. Agnew's General Strain Theory (1992) further explains that negative emotions like frustration, resentment, and anger contribute to criminal behavior. Kasab's personal grievances—poverty, lack of respect, and perceived oppression—were manipulated to drive him toward violent extremism (Agnew, 2010).

Social Control Theory: Weak Social Ties and Radicalization

Kasab lacked strong connections to conventional society, making him vulnerable to radical ideologies. Hirschi's (1969) social control theory suggests that people who have weak family bonds, poor education, and lack of employment are more likely to engage in criminal behavior.

After a fight with his father, Kasab left home, cutting ties with his family (Swami, 2009). He had minimal schooling, which limited his critical thinking skills and made him more susceptible to manipulation. Without strong community ties, he sought acceptance and purpose within LeT. Terrorist groups capitalize on such isolation, offering recruits a sense of belonging and purpose. Kasab's case illustrates how social disconnection can lead to radicalization and terrorism (LaFree & Dugan, 2004).

Conclusion

Ajmal Kasab's involvement in the 26/11 Mumbai attacks was not simply the result of personal choice but rather a complex interplay of social learning, strain, and weak social ties. Social theories of offending provide a framework to understand how terrorist organizations exploit economic hardship, social isolation, and ideological indoctrination to radicalize youth.

Kasab's radicalization was a systematic process: first, he was exposed to propaganda, then subjected to intensive training, and ultimately convinced that violence was justified. His case highlights the importance of counterterrorism measures that focus not only on security but also on social intervention, education, and rehabilitation. Preventing terrorism requires addressing the root causes of radicalization, including poverty, social alienation, and extremist propaganda.

By understanding the social mechanisms behind terrorism, policymakers and law enforcement can develop more effective strategies to combat radicalization and prevent future attacks.

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